



HOMOPHONES

Words that sound the same but mean different things

1 What is it?

Homophones (HOH-moh-fohnz)

Homophones are words that sound exactly the same when spoken aloud but have different spellings and different meanings.

same sound + different spelling + different meaning

2 See it in action

their/there/they're

"**They're** going to **their** house over **there**."

to/too/two

"I want **to** go **too**, with the other **two**."

your/you're

"**You're** right that **your** answer is correct."

its/it's

"**It's** clear the dog wagged **its** tail."



Good spot!

Test 'it's' by expanding it to 'it is' — if that doesn't make sense in your sentence, you need 'its' instead.

3 More to know

here/hear

"Come **here** so you can **hear** the announcement."

whether/weather

"I don't know **whether** the **weather** will hold."

FUN FACT

English has hundreds of homophone pairs, but "there/their/they're" is consistently ranked as the single most commonly confused set in both student writing and everyday adult emails.

4 Why it's used

Homophones help: matter hugely for accuracy in writing — mixing them up is one of the most common (and most noticeable) spelling errors, even though the sentence still sounds correct when read aloud.

A quick trick: "it's" only ever means "it is" or "it has" — if you can't substitute that in, use "its" instead. The same logic works for "they're" (they are) and "you're" (you are).



Quick reminder!

Read your work aloud slowly and picture the correct spelling in your head for tricky homophones — your ear can't catch a spelling mistake, but your eye can.

5 Where you'll spot it

Common pairs

to/too/two, their/there/they're, your/you're — these show up constantly in everyday writing and speech.

Spell-check blind spots

A homophone error slips past spell-check because both words are spelt correctly — just the wrong one for the sentence.

⚠ Watch out!

Spell-checkers often miss homophone errors completely, because the misspelled word is still a real, correctly-spelled word — just the wrong one. Always proofread these by eye.

6 Quick recap

Same sound, different spelling

Different meanings

Common source of errors



Keep going!

Keep a personal list of the homophones you mix up most often, and check for them specifically when you proofread.